

“The future is open by default”

Nikesh Balami, CEO, Open Knowledge Nepal, is an open data advocate and tech researcher. He is also associated with Code for Nepal as a programme coordinator, Artificial Intelligence for Development as a founding member, and the Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) Nepal community as an executive member.

Balami, in an exclusive interview with **Sreejani Bhattacharyya** of *OSFY*, talks about his open source journey, various achievements, and about how the FOSS ecosystem has developed in Nepal.

Nikesh Balami,
CEO, Open Knowledge Nepal



Nikesh Balami, CEO of Open Knowledge Nepal, says his journey in open source started with the rise of BackTrack and Kali Linux, which played a vital role in capturing his attention. That led to him developing an interest in doing different things with computers, while sitting in the college cafeteria and lab.

He adds, “This introduced me to the open source community of Nepal, named Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) Nepal. Members

of this community have been doing lots of wonderful activities to build the open source momentum. Their annual celebration of the Software Freedom Day is huge. Later, I started volunteering at this community with my friends and after a few gaps, we also established the Acme Open Source Community (AOSC) in our college. This community organised workshops, and trained and guided juniors towards open source opportunities.”

“Previously, open source software used to be about the flexibility of

customisation and adaption, but nowadays it’s all about the love for data and technology. I strongly believe in the vision of open source and open knowledge to empower citizens with technology usage and open data,” he goes on.

Maintaining consistency is key

Balami says that his professional role is now more focused on project curation, and that these days he helps manage Open Data Nepal. It is an initiative to make Nepal’s data accessible online

